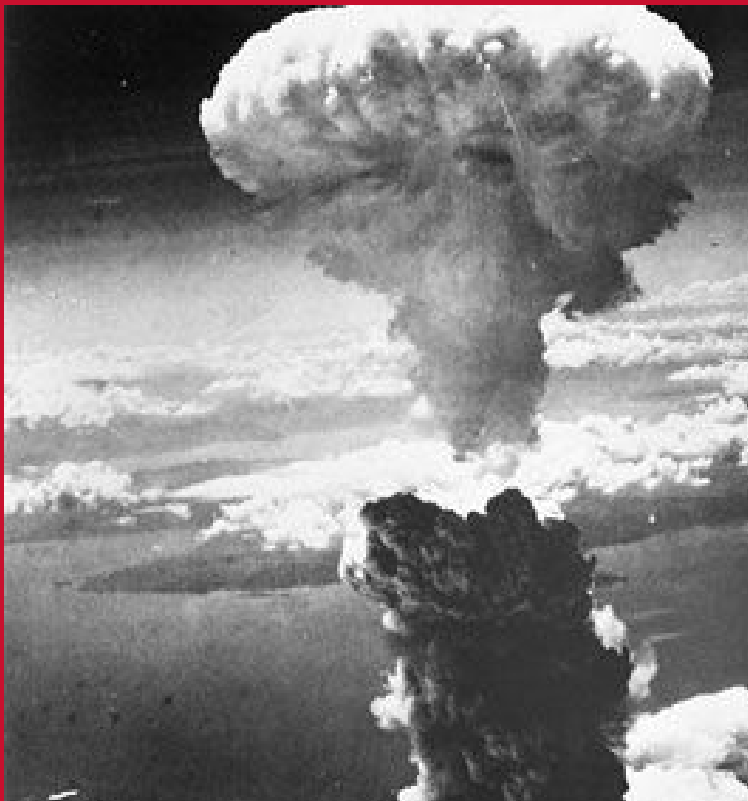


UPrep Model United Nations 2025



HCWC

Historical Committee: Cold War



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Director's Letter

Dear Delegates,

We are so excited to welcome you to the second annual iteration of UPrepMUN! It's great to see how many of you have signed up for the Historical Cold War Committee, given how important our history is to understanding the world today. We hope you'll develop a better understanding of the forces and processes that have shaped historical development, the subtleties and nuances of international diplomacy, and see the breadth of potential outcomes in any international crisis. There are always a lot of different ways things can end, and we're interested in seeing how the choices you make will parallel and differ from those of your historical counterparts. Maybe a better future is possible, but it'll be up to you to make it happen.

Sid Ramanathan, Chair

Sadie Stoddard, Assistant Director

Committee Overview

The Historical Cold War Committee will transport delegates back in time to the height of one of history's most intense geopolitical rivalries, where every decision could alter the balance of power. Through the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, this committee will explore the global impact of proxy wars and international conflicts. Delegates must navigate the complexities of military strategy, diplomacy, and ideological struggles, balancing national interests with global stability. The consequences of Cold War decisions continue to shape today's world, from ongoing regional conflicts and military alliances to the lingering mistrust between major powers. This committee will explore historical moments that continue to echo into today and that are key to understanding present-day international relations.

Topic A:

Soviet Invasion of Afghanistan

Topic Introduction

The Soviet invasion of Afghanistan was one of the key moments of the Cold War. It was the only time the Soviet Union directly invaded a country outside the Eastern Bloc, and what followed the initial intervention was a decade long guerilla conflict, with militant groups like the mujahideen receiving funding from and acting as proxies for Western powers such as the United States. The long term military engagement prompted widespread dissent at home for the Soviets, and arguably hastened the collapse of the Soviet Union. The Afghan intervention has been called “the Soviet Union’s Vietnam,” a striking and evocative parallel delegates may wish to consider carefully and perhaps place under some scrutiny.

While there are many unique features of the situation at hand, it is reminiscent of the many other proxy wars at this time. Both the United States and Soviet Union sought to maintain their vast networks of client and satellite states, and rejected the exit of states from their respective spheres of influence. Part of the Soviet justification for intervention was the Brezhnev Doctrine, which essentially argued if socialism in a socialist country was under threat, the Soviet Union was obligated to intervene. Simultaneously, the United States pursued a policy of containment, seeking to prevent and inhibit the spread of communism and Soviet influence, a policy which it would use to justify funding opposition to communism, which included a wide variety of social, economic, political, and religious groups.

Past Action

As mentioned earlier, the Soviet Union's invasion of Afghanistan has often been compared to the Vietnam War, so let's take a closer look at Vietnam to see how that proxy conflict played out. The Vietnam War was a pivotal Cold War conflict that drew international attention and engagement from far beyond just the two superpowers. What began as a civil war between communist North Vietnam and anti-communist South Vietnam soon became a global flashpoint, with the Soviet Union and the People's Republic of China supporting the North, and the United States and several allies, including Australia, South Korea, Thailand, and the Philippines, backing the South. Many countries, particularly those in Western Europe and parts of Asia, grew wary of the war's human cost and destabilizing effects, leading to diplomatic rifts even within allied blocs. Even within the United States, opposition to the war would grow, with anti-war protests erupting all over the country.

The war's conclusion in 1975, with the fall of Saigon and the unification of Vietnam under a communist government, dealt a psychological and strategic blow to the Western-aligned camp. However, it also demonstrated the immense cost of prolonged military intervention in a foreign country with strong nationalist resistance. This lesson resonated globally, not just in the United States but among other countries considering the risks of entanglement abroad. For the Soviet Union and its allies, the war was interpreted as both a victory for communism and a sign that the United States and its partners were reluctant to engage in long-term conflicts. This perception influenced Soviet confidence in extending influence into regions like Afghanistan, where the USSR sought to support a fragile communist government under threat from internal opposition and rising Islamist militancy.

At the same time, the Vietnam War experience influenced how countries in the Non-Aligned Movement, such as India, Egypt, and Yugoslavia, viewed superpower interventions. Many became increasingly vocal in condemning external interference and emphasizing the sovereignty of developing states, a theme that would return during debates over the Soviet presence in Afghanistan. The Vietnam War shaped not only the strategic calculations of the superpowers but also global attitudes toward foreign intervention, ideological expansion, and the rights of sovereign nations, all of which remain central to understanding the context of the Soviet-Afghan conflict.

Current Situation

In 1973, Mohammed Daoud overthrew Afghanistan's monarchy with the support of pro-Soviet factions, including the Marxist People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA). Initially aligned with Moscow, Daoud later distanced himself from Soviet influence, sought closer ties with the West, trying to suppress radical elements. His efforts failed, and in April 1978, the radical Khalq faction of the PDPA launched the Saur Revolution, killing Daoud and installing Noor Mohammad Taraki as Prime Minister. The U.S. reluctantly recognized the new regime, hoping to limit Soviet control.

Internal power struggles soon followed. Taraki and his deputy Hafizullah Amin cracked down on dissent, provoking revolts in conservative tribal regions. In 1978, Taraki signed a friendship treaty with the USSR, which included a provision that would allow direct Soviet military assistance should the Islamic insurgency threaten the regime. As civil unrest grew, Amin continued to consolidate power and eventually had Taraki killed in October 1979, seizing control. Alarmed by Amin's unpredictable behavior and the escalating insurgency, the USSR began to consider military intervention to stabilize the situation in Afghanistan.

On December 24, 1979, the Soviet Union invaded Afghanistan, killed Amin, and installed Babrak Karmal, a leader of the moderate Parcham faction, as head of a new pro-Soviet government.

Bloc Positions

Western Bloc

Australia, Austria, France, Greece, Italy, Japan, the Netherlands, Turkey, United Kingdom, United States, West Germany

These countries will likely condemn the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, support Afghan sovereignty, push for international sanctions and diplomatic isolation of the USSR, promote resolutions in the UN criticizing Soviet actions, and emphasize human rights and anti-communist unity within NATO.

Eastern Bloc

Bulgaria, Cuba, Czechoslovakia, East Germany, Hungary, Mongolia, Poland, Romania, USSR, Vietnam

These nations will likely support or justify the Soviet intervention as necessary to defend Afghanistan's socialist government, oppose Western interference, downplay the aggression narrative, and frame the invasion as a move to preserve regional stability and socialist progress.

Non-Aligned Movement and Other Unaligned States

Albania, Egypt, Ghana, India, Indonesia, Spain, Yugoslavia, People's Republic of China

These countries might call for Afghan sovereignty, denounce superpower interventionism from both the US and USSR, advocate for peaceful resolution through diplomacy, support non-alignment in global conflicts, and urge respect for national self-determination without Cold War influence, though opinions in this group will vary dramatically from country to country.

Guiding Questions

1. Why do proxy wars happen? How are they related to larger international conflicts or struggles?
2. How do ideologies and state belief systems drive countries, particularly with regards to international action?
3. How do international political blocs form and operate?
4. What is the relationship between ideologically aligned states? Are these sorts of blocs desirable?
5. What sorts of proxy groups receive funding? What sort of strategic benefits are there to funding militant groups? What are potential pitfalls or dangers? How do the ideologies of proxy groups relate to the countries they act as proxies for?
6. How can internal political differences in a country affect their international relations?
7. How do foreign policy doctrines impact the ways countries approach international issues? Are they too rigid or constrained?
8. How can we combat the use of foreign proxies to gain political and military influence? Would it be desirable to do that?

Further Research

[Council on Foreign Relations - Hot Wars During the Cold War](#): A summary of key conflicts during the Cold War, highlighting the concept of "hot wars" fought by superpowers and their allies.

[War on the Rocks - The Return of Great-Power Proxy Wars](#): An analysis of how great-power proxy wars are resurfacing in modern geopolitics, with a focus on global conflicts.

[American Archive - NewsHour Coverage of the Cold War in Afghanistan](#): Coverage of the U.S. involvement in Afghanistan during the Cold War, focusing on the role of news media.

[National Archives of Australia - Cold War Resources](#): A collection of resources that detail Australia's involvement in the Cold War and global military strategies during that time.

[Office of the Historian - Soviet Invasion of Afghanistan](#): A historical overview of the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and the United States' response, with insights into the political and military dynamics.

[Encyclopaedia Britannica - Brezhnev Doctrine](#): An explanation of the Brezhnev Doctrine, which justified Soviet intervention in Eastern Bloc countries to maintain communist control.

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